# Who Comes After Us?

Civic Skill: Long-Term Thinking | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

### LEARNING INTENTION

Children will extend their sense of temporal responsibility to include people they will never meet, future generations, building the foundation for intergenerational civic thinking.

## SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can think about people who aren't born yet but will live in this world.
- I can connect something we do now to how it might affect people in the future.
- I can say something I want to leave behind for people who come after us.

### MATERIALS

- A large class mural or collaborative art piece (begun over several sessions)
- Photographs of things that were built or planted long before the children were born (trees, buildings, community spaces)
- Picture book: 'The Lorax' by Dr. Seuss (abridged as needed), or 'Wangari's Trees of Peace' by Jeanette Winter
- A 'gift to the future' card for each child

## ACTIVITY STEPS

1. PHOTOGRAPH DISCUSSION (5 min): Show photos of old trees, historic buildings, or community spaces. 'Who planted this tree? Do you think they knew you would sit under it? They did something good for people they'd never meet. That's a kind of magic.'

2. BOOK READ (8 min): Read 'Wangari's Trees of Peace.' Wangari planted trees that would only be forests after she died. 'Why did she do it? Was it worth it?' Discuss: she cared about people she'd never meet.

3. COLLABORATIVE MURAL (10 min): 'We are going to make something for the children who will be in this room after us. Not for us — for them.' Add to a class mural that will be left in the space. Each child adds something with their name and a short message.

4. GIFT TO THE FUTURE (5 min): Each child draws or dictates one thing they want to leave for people who come after them. Read some aloud. Display them.

5. CLOSING: 'Every grown-up who ever planted a tree, or built a school, or cleaned a river — they were thinking about you. One day, someone will be glad you were thinking about them.'

### EXTENSIONS

- Connect to First Nations perspectives on caring for country across generations — with appropriate resources and ideally a community voice
- Visit or photograph something in your local area that someone built for the future
- Write a class pledge: 'Things we will leave for the people who come after us in this room'

### ASSESSMENT

- Gift card content: does the child's offering demonstrate consideration for others' needs, not just their own preferences?
- Observation: did any child spontaneously mention future people in conversation during other activities after this session?
- Document the mural — it is a long-term community artefact and a powerful portfolio piece

## EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How did children respond to the concept of caring for someone they'll never meet? What does that response tell you?
- What in your own teaching practice reflects this kind of long-term investment in the next generation?
- How does this lesson connect the individual child to a civic story that is larger than their own lifetime?

## EYLF LINKS

*This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 4 (Learning). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.*